

Φιλόδημος ὁ Γαδαρεύς

Philodemus of Gadara on Rhetoric and Epicurean Music

eul_aid: msu

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)

Dialect: Κοινή [Koine](#)

Domain: Φιλοσοφία [Philosophy](#)

Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)

Affiliation: [Epicurean](#)

Philodemus was a Greek philosopher and poet who lived from approximately 110 to 40 BCE. He was born in Gadara in the Hellenistic Near East and became a devoted follower of the Epicurean school. He studied under Zeno of Sidon, head of the Epicurean Garden in Athens, before moving to Italy around the 70s BCE. There he became part of the Roman elite, living and teaching at a villa in Herculaneum owned by the Roman statesman Lucius Calpurnius Piso.

Philodemus was a prolific writer on a wide range of subjects. His works, many surviving only in fragments, include treatises on ethics, theology, poetry, music, and rhetoric. Major titles include *On Poems*, *On Music*, *On Rhetoric*, *On Anger*, and *On the Gods*. He also composed short, witty epigrams.

The survival of his work is a historical accident of extraordinary importance. His entire personal library of papyrus scrolls was buried and carbonized during the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in 79 CE. These texts, known as the Herculaneum Papyri, have been painstakingly recovered and deciphered since the 18th century.

Philodemus is a figure of immense significance. He provides a crucial link for understanding how Greek Epicurean philosophy was transmitted and adapted in Roman intellectual circles. His recovered library offers a rare, direct look at a philosopher's working texts and the debates within his school. His theories on poetry and criticism are believed to have influenced later Roman poets, including Horace. Through both his life and his preserved writings, Philodemus offers a unique window into the philosophical and cultural exchange between the Greek and Roman worlds.

Works (2)

- ΠΕΡΙ ΡΗΤΟΡΙΚΗΣ · [On Rhetoric](#) · 151 passages
- Περὶ τῶν ὑπαρχόντων βιβλίων μουσικῆς · [On the Existing Books of Music](#) · 132 passages

Other Epicurean Authors

- Καρνεῖσκος ὁ Ἐπικούρειος · [Carneiscus the Epicurean](#) · 2 works
- Διογένης ὁ Οἰνοανδεύς · [Diogenes of Oenoanda](#) · 1 work
- Ἀνώνυμος Ἐπικούρειος · [Epicurean Anonymous](#) · 2 works
- Ἐπίκουρος ὁ φιλόσοφος · [Epicurus the Philosopher](#) · 8 works
- Ἑρμαρχος ὁ Μυτιληναῖος · [Hermarchus of Mytilene](#) · 1 work

- Μητρόδωρος ὁ Λαμψακηνός · Metrodorus of Lampsacus the Elder · 1 work
- Πολύστρατος ὁ Ἐπικούρειος · Polystratus the Epicurean · 2 works